continue to be the peer adversary for the US, though in the longer run it is not clear whether the US would be able to sustain a dual-adversary strategy.

These calculations may also be upended by the economic fallouts from the Ukraine war. Global recovery from the economic disruptions caused by the Covid-19 pandemic has been slow and halting. There will now be setbacks due to the war. Russia and Ukraine are the world's major suppliers of wheat, and disruptions in the wheat trade have already resulted in much higher prices of the cereal. It is the same story with the oil and gas trade and commodity trade in minerals and metals, where Russia is an important source of supply. Inflation, which was already trending across the world, is likely to accelerate, and it is possible that the world may face another era of 'stagflation', like it did in the decade of the 1970s. The pandemic has already given a fillip to trade protectionism and more self-reliant economic policies. These trends are likely to intensify, and there may be a more serious fragmentation of the global economy. India, too, will be impacted, as will China. There will be economic pain all round, but which countries will suffer the least pain and prove to be more resilient is not currently obvious. As we have seen, China under Xi Jinping has already been moving towards a more domestic-oriented and self-reliant economic strategy, and this is likely to be reinforced.

There is likely to be prolonged political and economic uncertainty in the aftermath of the Ukraine war. This geopolitical churn may lead to an unexpected set of power equations in the world. For India this will be a bigger and more complex challenge, but history tells us that periods of change and transformation also create opportunities for more nimble states to expand their strategic space and influence. India is well placed to explore these opportunities if it so chooses.

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